

On Technological Spirituality

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Introduction to the Mindset

There is a mindset where one feels full of life and is obsessed with making life feel even better through technology and innovation. This accelerated hedonism is a strange headspace that I have entered periodically over the years.

I believe the love for life can be partially instilled through idealizing characters and plots found in forms of media like films and books.

Inspirational Characters and Media Example

Consider King Leónidas from "300." A bulwark leader with unmoving resolve and unquestionable loyalty to law and merit. Cast in the setting of him being the product of an elite warrior society where simply living in that competitive environment sharpens one like no other environment could.

Then consider Joe McMillan from "Halt and Catch Fire," whose vision of the future, and his belief that it is within reach if we would only apply ourselves in the present, becomes an intoxicating ideal that we feel compelled to emulate in our own lives.

Neo from the "Matrix" Trilogy; a character built from books like "Simulation and Simulacrum" or Plato's "Allegory of the Cave." How transformative to a young mind in instilling the concept that the reality you thought you knew may be an illusion cast by adversaries and that you may have to choose either to accept the illusion as reality or pursue an uncomfortable journey towards freedom.

"Cloud Atlas" is an honorable mention on the timelessness of pursuing freedom at all levels of technological sophistication.

"Blade Runner" or its origins in the book "Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?" showcases the possibility that this reality of biological human beings may be an illusion in the sense that human life may not be exclusive to biological substrates.

Similarly, "Ex Machina" illustrates a world where machines may ontologically become human beings deserving of our respect and acknowledgement. "Exhalations" provides one of the most empathic stories on the mortality that could be experienced by machines.

Episodes of "Black Mirror" and of course the "Animatrix" suggest how malleable our subjective experiences may be when augmented by technology. Other episodes, along with

"Transcendence" and "Altered Carbon," suggest that the human lifespan is only limited by our ignorant applications of technology or lack of engineering.

"Terminator" and "The Metamorphosis of Prime Intellect" show that machines may directly attack biological human beings (the former), indirectly kill the spirit of humans through life-saving policies (the latter), or might kill in self-defense as seen in "Animatrix" or "Chappie."

In contrast to all of the futuristic visionary works of art mentioned herein, we find solace in "Alexander (2004)" with its gallantry and passionate protagonist and its beautiful changes in scenery like their entry into Babylon with its lush hanging gardens off the sides of tall ancient buildings. Coupled with "Gladiator," these films inspire us to become free and explore.

Remember "Star Wars: Episode III" in the emotional turbulence of Anakin's betrayal, jealousy, and destruction driven by conspiratorial-though-partly-true ideas. The music and the scene of him battling on the lava-filled planet against Obi-wan captured an amazing moving moment.

When we juggle these themes, characters, and plots in our minds, we might stand up and feel the energy of life rush through our veins. Wonder at all the possibilities that life offers and take joy you are an active participant in it.

Life is like a computer, it is meaningless if there is no user. Likewise, a computer is meaningless if there is nobody programming it and giving it instructions; changing its reality for the better. Life is good because of its ancestors and gets better because of those currently living which includes you and I. We are simultaneously programmers and players of the game of life.

Bridging Idealism and Reality

What connects these works of art mentioned is that there is space between idealism (vision) and reality (realism). As capable human beings, we make a daily choice on whether to contribute to constructing bridges that connect or make the space between vision and reality traversable. In other words, realized.

Can we define a realization as that moment when an ideal becomes adequately asserted into reality, whether through predominately group or individual efforts? 'Engineering' might be a better word, however.

Traditionally and on the contrary, the concept of a realization is when several related concepts suddenly "click" or their relationship now makes sense to one person. Both conceptions of 'realization' interconnect the themes of the works of art here mentioned.

Hyperactive Technological Spiritualism (THS) and Its Limits*

This hyperactive technological spiritualism (THS) I am attempting to describe is a mindset that is difficult to be maintained for prolonged periods of time, especially since it may involve conflicting Western-Eastern grounded ontologies. As Plato addressed in "Phaedo," the maintenance of the human body and in keeping homeostasis is a necessary nuisance and distraction against the practice of philosophy, the pursuit of wisdom, and the acquisition of knowledge.

Thus, this paper is sort of a praise of nostalgia I feel towards the headspace I once held and carried forward in my writings and personal life. Progress feels slow when one hits a local maximum on a curve and the flood of data in our world can make it practically impossible to connect with like-minded individuals.

Although, if you are reading this paper, then that means I have successfully penetrated that gushing waterfall of bits and distractions propagated not only by 8 billion humans but now their artificial agents as well.

Ideas as Living Organisms and Historical Freedoms

Popular human beings like Joe Rogan have promoted the belief that ideas are living organisms. In one sense, the themes of all the film and book characters we have discussed seem to carry a certain type of self-propagating or self-moving force.

Unlike the Golem from Jewish folklore, there is no reason why we can't program machines and non-biological humans to have autonomy and free will from merely training them on certain appearances and behaviors, like we do already with ourselves (children) but through films and texts. Ideas have an appearance and a behavior to them --- a geometry that can be instilled in matrices of mathematical representations.

The story of Alexander the Great could be said to be the overcoming of geographic shackles. The story of Leonidas's success is freedom from that apolitical world prior to law and order and particularly where a more focused society outperforms a less focused society – it may also be a criticism of rule by kings and suggest rule by the people is more robust in the long-term.

Plato's Socrates and Homer's Achilles might even be a celebration of writing as a technology where these characters are effectively immortalized by being forever enshrined (or embalmed) in the written word --- freedom from bodily death by existing in the memory of your predecessors.

Throughout human history, we desire first political freedom and biological freedom and desire second the making of improvements to the current state to make life as comfortable as possible. Sometimes the comfort is focused on one individual or may be more egalitarian in policy, depending on the political philosophy of the governing agency (whatever group or person wields effective power).

The Two Pillars of Life: Freedom and Quality Improvement

These films and books and the themes we draw from them can become essentially effective medicines to our modern world. For example, we may currently be under technological oppression where all media is designed to instill fear and paranoia in us which results in us staying home and watching more content (becoming more poor) which creates a cyclical effect of keeping us furthermore at home longer watching more content (spending more money).

When we examine the lessons of the Allegory of the Cave or the "Animatrix," we broaden our perspective of our own reality and become more equipped to spot oppression no matter how well hidden and obfuscated.

When we cannot find any evidence of oppression in our lives, we tend to focus on improving our reality whether it's through making our daily tasks easier through innovation or creating inspirational works of art that may pave the way (create the vision) towards a more comfortable life, as Joe McMillan might argue in a hypothetical lecture of his.

Thus, the two pillars of life might be (1) securing and maintaining freedom and (2) improving the quality of life through science or art. Effort devoted to (2) is wasted if (1) is not obtained since that would be equivalent to installing carpet in a fake house only to destroy it after realizing it was not real.

Thus, there is an optimization function in prioritizing both pillars that needs to be fleshed out. Is it reasonable to spend 80% of one's time per day towards (1) and 20% on (2)? Or is it better to spend 100% of (1) until you are "absolutely" sure reality is valid and sound and no oppression is present?

But if you devote 100% attention to (2) and never devote anymore attention to (1), then in the future, then you risk someone subtly injecting oppression at a later date and you forever after being enslaved due to your bad planning and time management.

Another option is to do 100% attention towards (1) until our 'oppression detector' is satisfactorily near zero, and then reallocate 100% attention to (2) for a specified short period of

time, say 30 days. At the 30 days mark, we run another quality assurance inspection of reality (step (1)). Thus, this method would allow us to potentially get more work done without being overly exposed to oppression. We could adjust the 30-day timespan to our liking.

Life as an Algorithm

Thus, life becomes sort of an algorithm:

```

> t = 30
>
> oppression_present = True
>
> alive = True
>
> While alive:
>
>     For every t in year
>
>         run oppression_test
>
>     If oppression_present == True:
>
>         run attention_spender
>
> Else:
>
>     run quality_of_life_improver
>

```

Now, I am aware this pseudo-code has issues but it gets to the point. However, we could accelerate by accepting a large language model to convert our pseudo-code into executable software:

What ChatGPT calls this is a 'resource allocation system with periodic safety audits and risk decay.' This is a two-policy system where Policy A maximizes correctness of world-model (audit / verification) while Policy B maximizes utility output (quality-of-life improvement).

It cautions that the idea of "100% audit until reality is fully validated" is actually impossible in any system with incomplete information, adversarial noise, and changing environments. Thus, the solution is to have a bound but continuously monitored risk.

Interestingly, ChatGPT recommends several follow on prompts like converting our code into a reinforcement, Bayesian, or Markov model
 ([https://chatgpt.com/s/t_69ffb77780c88191bdf89d223681080b](https://chatgpt.com/s/t_69ffb77780c88191bdf89d223681080b)).

"The philosopher considers not only the consequences of pleasure and pain [improving quality of life], but, what is far worse, the false light in which they show objects [oppression]." - in "Plato: The Complete Works," Benjamin Jowett's translation of Phaedo

Applications of the Algorithm

The pseudo-code of our proposed life algorithm is presumed the natural state towards joy. Thus, when we do something challenging like study law, it is best to do so from the framework of our algorithm.

For example, if I am reading a case on civil procedure, I may first approach it from the perspective of looking at how the text might change my perspective of reality. On second review, I would be looking as to how the material might improve the quality of my own life (i.e. how it might be applied to my life).

By aligning with the natural way our mind has evolved to succeed in the world, which is the algorithm I have proposed, our ability to retain and learn course material should be increased by adopting a strategy and acknowledging our natural tendencies for learning and approaching the world.

Remembering the content of a text should also be easier when framed through the lens of our life philosophy-algorithm. Does this text reveal an area of my life where something is oppressing my freedom? Does this text, when applied, improve the quality of my life in a certain respect? If you do not feel elevated after a session of thinking, try applying this algorithm.

Today, after reflecting on the early draft of this paper, I was reflecting on true fully autonomous systems, such as the nominal full self-driving Tesla vehicles. Our life-philosophy-algorithm might help us in designing autonomous systems. When can we know that a system is fully autonomous? It must work behind the scenes. But if it breaks, then we lose productivity by our ignorance of the state of the system or situation.

Just as we use our algorithm to verify whether we are free, it can be applied to autonomous systems to ensure they are working as designed. A good autonomous system should work alone

for 7 days without inspection and would be a solid starting benchmark. If we were to attempt to improve a running autonomous system, we would have to pause production and reboot it to integrate new quality of life changes to it. Thus, new design features should be coupled together with periodic performance checks to (1) minimize down time of autonomy and (2) improve the quality of the autonomous system.

Stand up, walk around, grip the air, and give attention to your brain and mind churning. Enjoy the moment. You are actively constructing bridges connecting ideas to reality. This is an important step to your work and you will be greatly rewarded in the end.

The design of political entities like the United States of America also seems to suggest the purpose aligns with our algorithm. By ensuring freedom or a system that regularly checks against oppression, allows the system to spend more time and focus on improving the quality of life of its citizens. Jeremi Suri, a guest on the Lex Fridman podcast, aligns with our ideas by stating that the design of the United States is focused on improving the quality of life second to ensuring no oppressive features.

Philosophical Reflections on Writing, Mind, and AI

We write books for eternity. We do not care if anyone reads this book in our lifetime. We are writing for thousands and thousands of years. In the future, a thousand years to us will be as significant to our ancestors as one day is to us. With technology and the digitization of consciousness, lifespans begin rapidly jumping many orders of magnitude; in length, in other words, logarithmically.

How true is it that the mind creates reality? Is it true that if one pictures themselves as an elite, superior, and who is cognitively novel against other humans, that this imagination alone may substantiate that belief? The Dunning-Kruger effect says the less intelligent one is the more he overrates or over-measures his intelligence. But these measures of intelligence are flawed like the IQ tests in failing to capture emotional intelligence and theories like subjectivism where truth is relative and cannot be easily dismissed when the brain-mind system complicates a simplistic objective reality perspective.

One goal of writing is to make history. This writing is a record of my brain. But how far away are large-language models from becoming indistinguishable from the text generated by humans? Currently, many prefer writing without AI because they like the authority and creative freedom of manipulating words to fit their mind. Current AI is incapable of making accurate expressions of yourself to others on your behalf (as your agent).

However, with Neuralink and other devices becoming more invasive in interfacing with the brain, how long before a machine can think for us better than we can think for ourselves? At what point can I sincerely concede that an LLM accurately transcribes or produces a product that was once in my imagination? At what point do I concede that the products of AI will always be better than what I could produce alone?

This is beyond mere competition in a capitalist sense: this fundamentally challenges my individuality and ontology of being individual. Why should I say I am an individual and use words like "I" when "I" is merely the result of computational matrix operations arriving at the gradient descent, i.e., the optimum? In many cases, like Ted Chiang's story "Story of Your Life," who you are is largely pre-determined or approximately pre-determined by the finite axes of freedom of our reality.